



Photographs by MAHADEO SEN

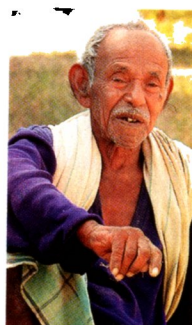
ing her in the lurch.

In some cases, even a father's decision to remarry has meant the end of the line for patients. For instance, 23-year-old Sulekha's father remarried and refused to take her home. She is cured but appears destined to stay in the company of mentally sick inmates. Two decades of pain and anguish is visible in septuagenarian Ratna Boral's eyes too. Deserted by her husband three decades ago, she still applies red vermilion as any married woman would. Worse still, some of these women like Maya are mothers, always missing their children. The last time Maya saw her son, he was six. "Today, he must be 22. How can he not remember me?" she cries. In some cases, women are also victims of dowry and property cases.

The institute's authorities admit that these inmates have recovered and are fit enough to join their fami-



LAXMI JAISWAL, 73
She was brought to RINPAS in 1985. Has not been discharged as her family had provided a wrong address while admitting her.



PORHA AHIR, 78
Admitted in 1955, he has been languishing here for the past 50 years as the asylum administration doesn't have his actual address.



RATNA BORAL, 64
Suffering from schizophrenia, was hospitalised in 1979 by her husband who had given wrong details, so has nowhere to go.



HARGOVIND PANDEY, 76
He was admitted in 1964. Has been declared fit for discharge since 1970, but his family has refused to take him back.

lies. "But we cannot let these patients go on their own," says a RINPAS official. This is not without reason. The Mental Health Act 1987, which replaced the Indian Lunacy Act of 1912 and came into effect in April 1993, maintains that patients of a mental hospital cannot be discharged unless someone from the government or a registered parent makes a request to this effect. But this has clearly gone against the inmates who seem to have been detained indefinitely as no relative has come forward to seek their discharge. The Act is silent on rehabilitation of such cured patients as a result of which a majority of these patients are forced to stay on in the asylum because their parents or husbands have entered a false address. This clearly indicates that the family had decided to get rid of the patient at the time they were admitting them. "In some cases, however, the family members have even refused to recognise or accept the inmates after our teams somehow managed to trace them," says Ranjan.

Incidentally, the families have often been extremely reluctant, especially in case of women. "A mentally unstable woman is considered a stigma on the family honour and is therefore considered unacceptable," explains sociology scholar Hetukar Jha. He believes that the patriarchal bias in society is the reason why married and mentally-ill women are sent back to their natal homes or abandoned in mental hospitals by their husbands, who also divorce them as fast as possible. This explains the prolonged stay of women in institutionalised care. Often, men are seen as being more indispensable to the family than a woman. The trend at RINPAS also confirms the argument. Only 125 of the total 495 patients admitted currently are women, but as many as 55 of them are on the abandoned list. Of the 91 patients abandoned by their families, only 36 are men.